

Selection-Reality Theory (SRT)

Main Ideas, Aims, and Relevance to the Present Question

Selection-Reality Theory (SRT) is best understood, at its current stage, as a philosophical framework and explanatory metatheory with formal ambitions, rather than as a completed scientific theory. Its central concern is actuality: how determinate reality, subjectivity, and durable public structure arise for finite, embodied operators under conditions of constraint, history, and cost.

Its starting claim is not that reality is invented by observers, but that actuality is achieved. A state becomes actual, in the relevant sense, insofar as it is selected from a wider field of possibilities, stabilized into a locally maintainable form, and sustained under finite conditions. SRT therefore asks not only what exists, but also how actuality is generated, under what constraints it persists, and what burden is incurred in that process.

1. Selection and actuality

The first guiding idea of SRT is that selection is prior to determinate existence in a structural sense. A state is not yet actual merely because it is logically or formally possible. It becomes actual insofar as it is selected and stabilized for a finite operator. This is not meant as a voluntarist thesis: selection is never unconstrained, and SRT does not suggest that subjective preference freely creates reality. The claim is narrower. It is that actuality is not best understood as a fully finished background that is simply read off, but as a structured achievement under finite conditions.

2. The triadic articulation of reality

SRT formulates this through a threefold distinction.

- L_0 denotes the latent domain of open possibility: what is not yet selected or stabilized.
- L_1 denotes the manifest slice: the currently actualized and locally maintained reality-slice within which a finite operator acts.
- L_2 denotes stabilized convergence: historically hardened patterns that acquire durability through repetition and multi-operator coordination, including laws, habits, conventions, institutions, and public languages.

These are not three separate worlds or substances. They are three structural moments of one process: possibility, manifestation, and stabilization. This triadic articulation is one of the features that gives SRT an identity independent of any one existing observer-centred

framework, since it is designed to account not only for private experience but also for the emergence of durable public structure.

3. Operator-dependence and objectivity as convergence

A further claim of SRT is that every manifest reality-slice is operator-bound. There is no actuality as accessed from nowhere. Reality, as manifest for a finite system, is always filtered through a parameterized selection operator, written as $\hat{G}_\theta$, where θ denotes the operator's concrete conditions of access, including bodily organization, memory, temporal horizon, energetic budget, and other finite constraints.

This operator-dependence does not imply solipsism, nor does it abolish objectivity. Rather, SRT relocates objectivity. Objectivity is not treated as a metaphysically untouched background prior to all finite access; it is treated as the stabilized convergence of many finite operators onto sufficiently durable structures. In this sense, objectivity is understood as convergence rather than as an absolute view-from-nowhere.

4. Ontological friction and concern structure

A central component of the framework is the notion of ontological friction, denoted by Ψ_f . This is meant to capture the burden involved in selecting, maintaining, and transforming a reality-slice under finite conditions. SRT does not identify Ψ_f simply with subjective effort, pain, or energy expenditure, although these may function as local indicators in particular contexts. More generally, Ψ_f names the structural resistance involved in compressing open possibility into a maintainable actuality. It can be read dynamically as resistance, economically as cost, and formally as reconfiguration burden between maintainable states.

SRT couples this with a second variable, d , intended to track the operator's concern structure. Informally, d may be described as concern bandwidth or scope of care: how many dimensions of possibility matter non-trivially to the operator. Formally, SRT treats d as an effective-dimension or participation-ratio index over the eigenvalues λ_i of the operator's selection structure:

$$d(\hat{G}) = \frac{(\sum_i \lambda_i)^2}{\sum_i \lambda_i^2}$$

The purpose of introducing d is to distinguish mere predictive or functional organization from stake-bearing subjectivity. A system may be highly adaptive, stable, or intelligent and yet, on the SRT view, fail to qualify as a subject in the stronger sense if nothing is genuinely at stake for it. For this reason, SRT does not treat predictive success, global integration, or error minimization as sufficient conditions for subjectivity. What matters, rather, is the conjunction of a nontrivial concern structure and a nonzero, internally binding burden of actuality.

5. Internal irreversibility and the present question

The aspect of SRT most relevant to the present exchange concerns the notion of stakes. Here the term is meant in a structural rather than primarily ethical or phenomenological sense. A transition is stake-bearing when it closes alternatives in a manner that is not simply reversible from within the system's own resources. SRT refers to this, cautiously, as internal irreversibility or ontological fragility.

This is the background for one of SRT's working contrasts:

- **(A)** a biologically embodied observer whose future includes losses, injuries, or failures that are not recoverable from within the system's own organization;
- **(B)** an observationally identical simulated observer whose local state can, in principle, be reinstated by an external rollback or backup structure.

The SRT hypothesis is not simply that biology is real and simulation is unreal. The narrower claim is that thermodynamic and historical embedding may matter to whether a transition is genuinely consequential for the operator, even when current informational structure is held fixed. At the physical level, Landauer's principle functions as an important anchor for this line of thought, because it indicates that irreversible information erasure has a thermodynamic lower bound. SRT does not reduce its ontology to Landauer's principle, but takes it as a useful marker that irreversibility need not be merely semantic or psychological.

6. Aims and relation to Algorithmic Idealism

1. SRT has four closely related aims. First, it seeks to offer a general account of actuality: not merely what exists, but how actuality is generated from possibility under finite, embodied, and costly conditions. Second, it seeks to provide a common conceptual grammar across domains. It does not aim to eliminate domain-specific mechanisms in physics, biology, cognition, or social theory, but to ask whether these domains can be read as scale-specific unfoldings of a more general architecture of selection, stabilization, concern, and friction. Third, it seeks to clarify the relation between subjectivity and objectivity by treating subjectivity as operator-bound manifestation and objectivity as stabilized multi-operator convergence. Fourth, it seeks to distinguish predictive or functional competence from stake-bearing existence, especially in discussions of consciousness, artificial systems, and normativity.
2. These commitments are what make SRT an independent framework. Its distinctive content lies in the combination of a triadic articulation of reality, an operator-bound account of manifestation, a convergence account of objectivity, a constitutive role for ontological friction and payability, and a formal distinction between predictive organization and stake-bearing subjectivity. This independence does not preclude substantial overlap with existing observer-centred approaches.

3. SRT also shares substantial ground with observer-centred approaches such as Algorithmic Idealism. Both reject naive third-person realism as the sole legitimate starting point. Both take the first-person/third-person asymmetry seriously at the foundations. Both allow apparently lawlike worlds to emerge from deeper structural regularities rather than presupposing them as metaphysically basic.
4. The possible divergence, as SRT presently formulates it, is narrower. Algorithmic Idealism asks, in effect: given an observer-state, what should be expected next from the first-person perspective? SRT asks an additional question: what makes some transitions count as genuinely consequential for a finite operator at all? The intended relation is therefore not one of simple opposition. SRT may instead be read as preserving much of the observer-centred starting point while asking whether internal irreversibility, payable friction, and stake-bearing consequence require an additional layer of theory.

7. Present status

SRT should therefore be read as a framework under development: philosophically ambitious, structurally organized, and increasingly formalized, but still in the process of sharpening its comparative and empirical interfaces. Its present value lies in offering a disciplined vocabulary for connecting actuality, embodiment, concern, convergence, and stakes. Its central open task is to determine how far these distinctions can be rendered formally precise and empirically discriminable.